named LPM-0. This was quickly followed by 30 kg and 200 kg thrust engines. Another team comprising A Chandran, Sivaramakrishnan and E V S Namboodiri had put together a 600 kg thrust liquid engine.

The Americans, Russians and the French were using 240-tonne cluster engines using four 60 tonners. In comparison, our 600 kg engine was but a tad better than a Diwali rocket. Nevertheless, I made an attempt to put together a rocket using the engine. Since a 600 kg thrust was too meagre for a launch, we used a solid booster, and soon a two-stage rocket called LP-006 was ready for testing.

The solid propulsion groups working within SSTC and TERLS were still unconvinced about the possibilities of a liquid engine, and this fired my ambition more. After successful ground tests, we had the rocket at the Sriharikota launch pad.

It was a sunny morning at Sriharikota on 15 May 1973 when LP-006 lifted off with the first stage solid booster and the liquid engine as the second stage. All eyes, literally, were on the liquid stage. A few seconds after the rocket rose to the sky, it disappeared from our sight. And the radar didn't pick up any signals from the rocket thereafter. Since the rocket had no payload which could have communicated to the ground station, there was no way to confirm if the second stage performed as planned.

A majority of the scientists who had gathered at Sriharikota, including quality control head M C Mathur, said the launch was a failure. I argued it was a success. My logic was simple: the radar might have been at fault. And, with the sun bright on the eastern sky, we could not see the second stage ignition and performance, which could have been possible on a clear night sky.

Throwing a challenge at the majority who called the launch a failure, I said we are ready with a second LP-006 engine and my team could launch it within a month. This time we would do it on a night, when the sky is clear, so that we can see with our naked eye, the entire burnout of the rocket, irrespective of the performance of the radar. My detractors, possibly convinced that I would bite the dust, agreed.